

Team deathmatch?

Teams of hackers or security experts are often called tiger teams or red teams

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The free software movement is a heavily infused with the same principles as the hackers ethics

Geek life

programmers to justify their sinful ways. Hacking sounds just too violent and in most other contexts it would involve masked men lopping off body parts. How can people accessing your data without invitation be considered ethical?

The perception is the issue. Surely it is wrong of a person to barge into your home but if he really did is just to appreciate your lawn, you might throw in a few concessions. That is the truth about the White Hat hackers today. They aren't barging into your home to steal your money, they do so because of the thrill of it, they do it because of the challenge, and most importantly they do it so they can point out to you just exactly how many times you need to turn the key in the lock.

The reason this is confusing is that the ones we are securing from are Hackers themselves, but without the ethical code that the White Hat hackers follow. Describe These people are known as Black Hat hackers or crackers. Their motivation is not just curiosity, but a desire for profit, or even just a malevolent joy in disrupting others. Like with most things the malicious few ruin things for the others. We are more inclined to see a serial killer in a muscular man carrying a large knife than to recognize him as the friendly neighbourhood coconut vendor.

In any other field of security, whether it be bullet-proof glass or car bodies, or bank safes, we expect the companies to do the best they can to ensure that our security is never compromised. How do you know whether a glass is bulletproof till you shoot it, or how safe a car is till you crash it? How do you know your computer firewall is strong enough to resist any penetration.

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The job of an ethical hacker is to judge the level of security of any computing infrastructure. In order to do this they may have to subject it to the same kind of treatment that a malicious entity might. They need to discover any open routes of attack, any unsecured entry into the system.

The intent behind performing a penetration test is to evaluate if a system is ready to be deployed in an environment like the internet, where it is open to attack. To obtain a full security audit a penetration test can reveal a lot about how susceptible the system might be to attack, how measures may be taken to avoid such breaches, and what would be the impact of such a breach on the company and its data (if it were to happen). Since any system is bound to be susceptible to an



attack of some form or the other, how seriously the threat will be taken will obviously depend on how feasible the attack is and how serious is its impact.

To fully secure a system it needs to be tested under all possible scenarios. For any external attack on the system the attackers will most probably be unaware of the specifications of the system. Simulating such attacks is called BlackBox Testing. To test the resilience of the infrastructure to attacks from an internal party which may be partially or fully aware of the systems' configuration, a WhiteBox test is performed.

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A black box is meant to signify a closed opaque system where you cannot immediately determine the composition of its contents. Every time you play around with a new closed source software which you know nothing about, you are in a way doing some blackbox testing of your own.

Real blackbox test, meaning testing which is done in order to ascertain the security of a system (and not say finding out how to create a cube in Lightwave 3D) is much more complex. It is like handing a microwave oven to someone in the 1800s and telling them to make a roast turkey. For this reason blackbox testing is not something which can be automated, and requires extensive work by a professional hacker.

Since Black Box testing is independent of the internals of the system, it can expose bugs in the system which can be missed even by people who have full knowledge of the system. However it is difficult to be exhaustive, since the tester has no knowledge about the range of tests that need to be performed.

While playing around with something you don't have any knowledge about, there is always a chance that you will break things. However this is a risk that often has to be taken in order to ensure



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